tion groups. For instance, only 25.8 per cent of Gen Z respondents rate Modi's performance as 'outstanding', compared with 30.1 per cent overall. Similarly, fewer young respondents see Modi as 'best suited to be India's next prime minister'—43.9 per cent, against 48.7 per cent among all respondents. The gap may not appear dramatic, but for a generation that will account for an increasingly decisive share of the electorate, it is a warning sign the BJP can ill afford to ignore.

Gen Z's frustration becomes especially combustible when its faith in meritocracy and fairness begins to crumble. Middle-class families invest heavily in education and coaching on the assumption that hard work and ability will eventually be rewarded. Paper leaks and examination controversies strike at the integrity of that compact, fuelling demands for greater accountability. Young voters also strongly disapprove of political parties and leaders constantly shifting allegiances in pursuit of power, viewing such behaviour as unethical and yet another example of a system in need of change. Yet this does not translate into a wholesale rejection of the BJP's larger ideological agenda. On several major political questions, Gen Z is broadly in sync with the rest of the electorate: support for a Uniform Civil Code is virtually identical, as are views on caste reservations and illegal immigration, while enthusiasm for Viksit Bharat remains strong.

BJP'S FRAYING COMPACT

Yashwant Deshmukh, founder of CVoter, which conducts the MOTN poll for INDIA TODAY, believes the compact that has sustained the dominance of Modi and the BJP is beginning to fray at the edges. One mistake, he argues, is the government's tendency to counter people's lived economic distress with statistics showing unemployment and inflation at relatively low levels. As he puts it, "Rising prices is something they feel while buying items like milk, sugar or petrol, and you cannot throw statistical jargon at them because they are living the inflation."

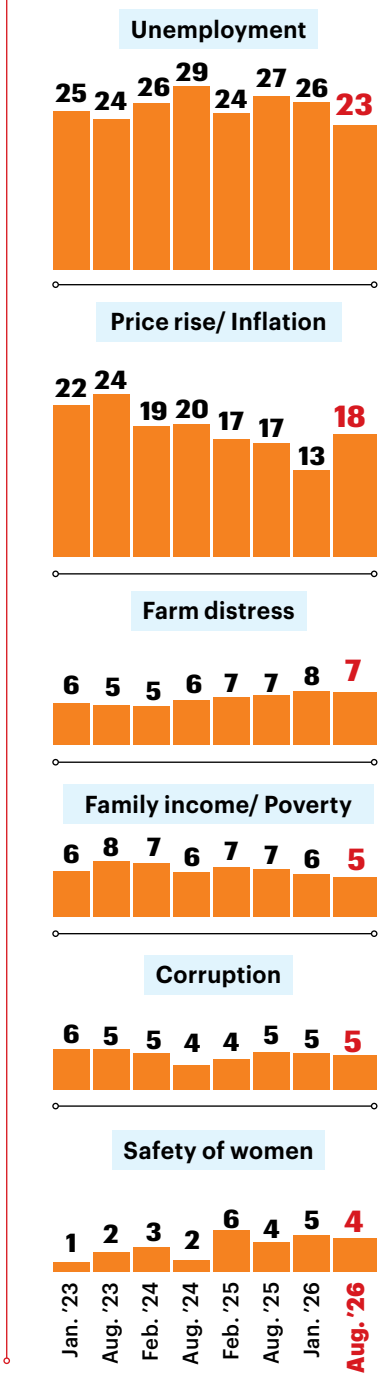
The other challenge is the ruling party's seeming disconnect with Gen Z. Deshmukh points out that this generation has little political memory of the UPA years and that, by the 2029 Lok Sabha election, roughly 30 per cent of voters will have known only BJP rule at the Centre. Consequently, the BJP's old tactic of



PTI

FULL STEAM AHEAD Inauguration of a Namo Bharat corridor and the Meerut metro services, Feb. 22





All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say